



**SOMETHING OLD,
SOMETHING NEW:
Basgo's monastery
is a work of history,
in progress**

■ **By Aijaz Hussain**

Deep inside Ladakh's rugged but seductive landscape, at 11,500 ft above sea level atop a hillock, a 16th-century Buddhist monastery is coming alive. And not because of the Archaeological Survey of India (ASI) or the Government. The people of Basgo village are resurrecting their own heritage. Standing amid sharp, barren mountain cliffs which once protected it from invading enemies, Basgo is not just a remote village—it is also one forgotten by almost everyone except those who care for its living monastery. Overlooking lush apricot and apple groves, volunteers of the Basgo Welfare Committee (BWC), both men and women, fill the air with religious hymns, all the while carrying backloads of crushed stone and sand for use in the restoration of their beloved monument. On the eastern cliffs of the village, the Basgo monastery is a complex of a ruined castle and three gompas (temples) that house three statues of Maitreya Buddha, the tallest being 48 ft. The complex, historically known as Rabstan Lhartse Khar, was built in 1450-1650 AD when Basgo valley was the seat of power for a branch of the Royal Namgyal family in Ladakh. When Mongol and Tibetan armies invaded Ladakh towards the end of the 17th century, the Basgo complex withstood a three-year-long siege and forced the mighty armies to retreat.

In 1992, a native returned from Kashmir armed with an engineering degree and a vision to restore the village's faded history. The young engineer, Tsering Wangchuk, soon got the 170 households to join hands. The village's sense of heritage also won patronage from a local settled in the far-away US, Buddhist scholar Lozang Jamspal. The work began in 1999 but the real fillip came in 2000 when the US-based World Monuments Fund listed the complex among the world's 100 most endangered heritage sites and provided monetary help. "Before any external help came, we initiated the work of renovating roofs of all the three temples in 1999," says Wangchuk, the general secretary of BWC. "Then there was no looking back," recalls Wangchuk. In 2002, the Namgyal Institute for Research on Ladakhi Art and Culture joined hands with experts in structural engineering, architecture and painting conservation. Next, Unesco pitched in and funded the community initiative to restore priceless cracked paintings and the ancient crumbling ancient walls. A library is also being constructed within the complex that will house 108 volumes of rare Buddhist teachings and other manuscripts. "We deserve to inherit our past," says 74-year-old Sonam Rabgias, who supervises the work. From the seat of power to an ordinary village in Ladakh, Basgo is set to reclaim its past glory. This time it's not the all-powerful kings with their retainers but ordinary citizens enhanced with brick and mortar who are pitching in their work days and their savings. They have laid a new foundation to restore the pride of an entire community.

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